Body of an American

By John Dos Passos

*WhereastheCongressoftheunitedstatesbyaconcurrentresolutionadoptedonthe 4thdayofmarchlast-authorizedtheSecretaryofwartocausetobebroughttothe unitedstatesthe **body of an American** whowasamemberoftheAmericanexpeditionary forceineuropewholosthislifeduringtheworldwarandwhoseidentityhasnotbeenestablished forburialinthememorialamphitheatreofthenationalcemeteryatarlingtonvirginia*

INTRODUCTION

The bodies of many soldiers killed in World War I could not be identified. To honor them, the remains of one were brought to the U.S. Capitol to lie in state, and on Armistice Day 1921 they were ceremoniously buried in Arlington National Cemetery. The tomb bears the inscription "Here rests in honored glory an American soldier known but to God." Congress later directed that an "Unknown American" from subsequent wars -- World War II, Korea and Vietnam -- be similarly honored. Because of the development of DNA technology, the Unknown Soldier from the Vietnam War was recently exhumed and identified. There may never be another unknown soldier. At this time of our continued war on terrorism throughout the world it seems fitting to reflect upon our first world crisis with John Dos Passos's tribute to all those young, unidentified men of WWI, who gave up their lives in honor of their country . . . Body of an American by John Dos Passos.

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In the tarpaper morgue at Chalons-sur-Marne in the reek of chloride of lime and the dead, they picked out the pine box that held all that was left of enie menie minie moe plenty of other pine boxes stacked up there containing what they'd scraped up of Richard Roe and other person or persons unknown. Only one can go. How did they pick John Doe? . . .

how can you tell a guy's a hundredpercent when all you've got's a gunnysack full of bones, bronze buttons stamped with the screaming eagle and a pair of roll puttees?

. . . and the gagging chloride and the puky dirtstench of the yearold dead . . .

The day withal was too meaningful and tragic for applause. Silence, tears, songs and prayer, muffled drums and soft music were the instrumentalities today of national approbation.

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John Doe was born (thudding din of blood of love into the shuddering soar of a man and a woman alone indeed together lurching into and ninemonths sick drowse waking into scared agony and the pain and blood and mess of birth). John Doe was born and raised in Brooklyn, in Memphis, near the lakefront in Cleveland, Ohio, in the stench of the stockyards in Chi, on Beacon Hill, in an old brick house in Alexandria Virginia, on Telegraph Hill, in a halftimbered Tudor cottage in Portland the city of roses, in the Lying-In Hospital old Morgan endowed on Stuyvesant Square, across the railroad tracks, out near the country club, in a shack cabin tenement apartmenthouse exclusive residential suburb;
scion of one of the best families in the social register, won first prize in the baby parade at Coronado Beach, was marbles champion of the Little Rock grammarschools, crack basketballplayer at the Booneville High, quarterback at the State Reformatory, having saved the sheriff's kid from drowning in the

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Little Missouri River was invited to Washington to be photographed shaking hands with the President on the White House steps; —

though this was a time of mourning, such an assemblage necessarily has about it a touch of color. In the boxes are seen the court uniforms of foreign diplomats, the gold braid of our own and foreign fleets and armies, the black of the conventional morning dress of American statesmen, the varicolored furs and outdoor wrapping garments of mothers and sisters come to mourn, the drab and blue of soldiers and sailors, the glitter of musical instruments and the white and black of a vested choir— busboy harveststiff hogcaller boyscout champeen cornshucker of Western Kansas bellhop at the United States Hotel at Saratoga Springs office boy callboy fruiter telephone lineman longshoreman lumberjack plumber's helper, worked for an exterminating company in Union City, filled pipes in an opium joint in Trenton, N.J.

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Y.M.C.A. secretary, express agent, truckdriver,
fordmechanic, sold books in Denver Colorado: Madam
would you be willing to help a young man work his way
through college?

President Harding, with a reverence seemingly more
significant because of his high temporal station,
concluded his speech:

We are met today to pay the impersonal tribute; the
name of him whose body lies before us took flight with
his imperishable soul . . .

as a typical soldier of this representative democracy he
fought and died believing in the indisputable justice of
his country's cause . . .

by raising his right hand and asking the thousands with
the sound of his voice to join in the prayer:

Our Father which art in heaven hallowed by thy name . . .

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John Doe's
heart pumped blood:
alive thudding silence of blood in your ears

down in the clearing in the Oregon forest where the
punkins were punkincolor pouring into the blood through
the eyes and the fallcolored trees and the bronze
hoopers were hopping through the dry grass, where tiny
striped snails hung on the underside of the blades and
the flies hummed, wasps droned, bumble-bees buzzed,
and the woods smelt of wine and mushrooms and apples,
homey smell of fall pouring into the blood,

and I dropped the tin hat and the sweaty pack and lay
flat with the dogday sun licking my throat and
adamsapple and the tight skin over the breastbone.

The shell had his number on it.

The blood ran into the ground.

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The service record dropped out of the filing cabinet
when the quartermaster sergeant got blotto that time
they had to pack up and leave the billets in a hurry.

The identification tag was in the bottom of the Marne.

The blood ran into the ground, the brains oozed out of
the cracked skull and were licked up by the trenchrats,
the belly swelled and raised a generation of blue-bottle
flies.

and the incorruptible skeleton,

and the scraps of dried viscera and skin bundled in khaki

they took to Chalons-sur-Marne
and laid it out neat in a pine coffin
and took it home to God's Country on a battleship
and buried in a sarcophagus in the Memorial
Amphitheatre in the Arlington National Cemetery

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and draped the Old Glory over it
and the bugler played taps

and Mr. Harding prayed to God and the diplomats and
the generals and the admirals and the brasshats and the
politicians and the handsomely dressed ladies out of the
society column of theWashington Post stood up solemn

and thought how beautiful sad Old Glory God's Country it
was go have the bugler play taps and the three volleys
made their ears ring.

Where his chest ought to have been they pinned

the Congressional Medal, the D.S.C., the Medaille
Militaire, the Belgian Croix de Guerre, the Italian gold
medal, the Vitutea Militara sent by Queen Marie of
Rumania, the Czechoslovak war cross, the Virtuti Militari
of the Poles, a wreath sent by Hamilton Fish, Jr., of New
York, ... All the Washingtonians brought flowers.

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Woodrow Wilson brought a bouquet of poppies.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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